

Alienation and the Zeitgeist



Hegel believed that there is a single reality, and that this is essentially not material, but what he called *Geist*, or Spirit. The phenomena we perceive, even our own thoughts and consciousness, are simply aspects of this one Spirit, which is continually evolving in time through a process of dialectic. As a result, each period of time has its own different Spirit, the *Zeitgeist* or Spirit of the age, in which our way of thinking and consciousness is at a specific stage in its development.

We are all caught up in this *Zeitgeist*, living within its ideas and institutions, which we also play a part in creating. However, these often constrain us with codes of conduct that may be alien to the way we would like to live. Despite being part of the *Zeitgeist*, our own ideas can be out of tune with the world around us, and we feel a sense of ‘alienation’ from the very social and political institutions we have created. This may even extend to our religious institutions, by projecting our ideals onto a God who is separate from our world.